

Hosting Decision Brief

SIMF, Saudi International Maritime Forum

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Prepared for the project owner. Decision required.

1. The decision

The platform is built and deployed, and it is not yet launched. It runs today on a local Saudi host reached through STC. The correct home for it is SITE, because the Ministry's systems are hosted there and Ministry approval depends on being there. SITE hosts the platform once its requirements are met. The forum date is the reason the work is currently running on STC rather than on SITE.

The choice is therefore not about technology. It is about which of two things to accept: a delay, or the absence of Ministry approval.

In one line. Moving to SITE buys Ministry approval and costs time. Staying on STC holds the forum date and forfeits approval. How much time is the one number this brief cannot yet give, because it is set by the design rebuild, and the rebuild cannot be estimated until the design standard is obtained. Section 6, decision 2, is how that number gets found.

1.1 What the owner should know first

The High Level Design, already delivered to the Ministry, states that hosting is on the SITE Private Cloud, names SITE as the provider of the private cloud, the mail relay and the inference server, and assigns six of its eleven open items to SITE. The Solution Design Document and the Business Requirements Document describe the platform as running on premises without naming a host, and name SITE only as the supplier of the AI model and the mail relay.

The internal architecture and operations documents say something different again. They record the host as a local Saudi provider reached through STC, which is where the platform actually runs.

So the design delivered to the Ministry and the system actually running disagree about who hosts the platform. This is not a drafting error to be tidied away. Whichever way this decision goes, one of the two has to change: either the platform moves to SITE, or the High Level Design is reissued to describe STC. That is the first cost of leaving the decision open.

2. The two options, against the owner's own criteria

The four criteria below are the ones the owner asked to weigh. Each is answered for both paths.

Criterion	Go to SITE	Stay on STC for the 2026 forum
Compliance and approval	The approved position. The Ministry's systems are hosted at SITE, and approval follows from being there. It also makes the High Level Design true, since that document already names SITE as the host.	No Ministry approval for the hosting. The platform runs outside the estate the Ministry's systems sit in, and the High Level Design describes a host that is not the one in use.
The forum date	At risk, by an amount not yet known. One requirement clearly moves the date: the design of	Protected. This is the reason the work is on STC today, and it remains the only path that does not

Criterion	Go to SITE	Stay on STC for the 2026 forum
	all three clients must be rebuilt to the national design standard. The migration itself is cheap while the platform is pre-launch. The rebuild is not, and it cannot be sized until the standard is obtained.	reopen the design.
Cost and contract	A redesign of three clients, a migration, and a contract change. SITE takes publishing, deployment, operation, testing and monitoring, so the delivery contract narrows to building the software and handing it over.	No new build cost now, but it is not free. The High Level Design must still be reissued to describe STC, and the design standard must still be obtained so the rebuild can be scheduled. The rest of the cost is deferred rather than avoided, because the move to SITE still has to happen for approval, and it is more expensive after launch than before.
Control and support	Reduced. The team could not release a fix or examine production during the forum without SITE. For a three-day event that cannot be rescheduled, that is an operational risk to plan for.	Retained. The team publishes, deploys, tests and monitors, and can act within minutes during the event.

3. What SITE requires

SITE's requirements arrive from two places: a set of infrastructure constraints given directly, and a sixty-three item technology and methodology checklist returned with a status against each item. Much of it is already answered by the design.

3.1 Already answered by the design

These need no design work and are recorded here as settled. The third column matters: several are satisfied by the design but not yet by the system as deployed, because the deployment runs on STC and the servers SITE would supply do not exist yet. Moving to SITE is what closes that column.

SITE requirement	In the design	In the deployment today
Artificial intelligence must run locally	Met. The model runs on an on-site server inside the high security area, reached through a provider abstraction.	Not yet. The deployment is configured for a cloud provider. The on-site server is supplied by SITE and does not exist on the current host.
Object storage on MinIO	Met. Files are held in MinIO, with only object keys in the database.	Not yet. The running system stores files on the server's own disk. MinIO is provisioned by SITE before go-live.
No internet access from the high security area	Met. The design gives that area no route to the internet.	Not applicable. The high security area is part of the SITE design and does not exist on the current host.
Three-tier deployment	Met. Each layer of the system runs on its own servers.	Met in the production layout.
No sign language capability	Met. Withdrawn from scope.	Met. Two unused connection points remain in the software and are deleted before handover; nothing calls them.
Access token no longer than five minutes	Met. Five minutes.	Met.
Session no longer than one day	Met. A twenty-four hour absolute cap.	Met.

3.2 What must change

Two requirements are not met, and a third is already decided and recorded here so it is not reopened.

Requirement	What it means
The design is rejected. All three clients must follow the national design standard.	This is the only requirement that clearly moves the launch date. It is explained in section 4.1.
SITE takes publishing, deployment, operation, testing and monitoring, including the mobile application stores.	The delivery contract narrows to building the software and handing it over. The code moves into SITE's own development tooling, which settles five outstanding checklist items at once.

Requirement	What it means
No live streaming through YouTube.	Already decided. Live video is dropped and sessions are published for viewing afterwards. Note what this does not do: it does not close the platform's one outbound internet call. Live video never was that call, because it plays from YouTube to the attendee's own device rather than through the platform. The outbound call is the Control Panel fetching the subtitle track from the published video, which feeds the automatic session summary. Closing that too means an administrator supplying the transcript instead, which the design already allows for.

3.3 The checklist, in proportion

Sixty-three items were assessed. Forty-one were approved outright, four approved with comments, four rejected and fourteen marked for discussion. Twenty-two of the sixty-three therefore need attention, and they are not spread evenly: eight of the nine security items, all five delivery and automation items, and four of the six client-side items. Methodology, team structure, quality standards and the entire list of deliverables passed untouched.

One of those twenty-two could be larger than everything else in this brief. Two of the four client-side items are the Android and iOS applications themselves, which SITE marked for discussion with a note about cyber approval for a native codebase only. Until that is settled, it is not known whether SITE accepts the technology the mobile application is built in. If it does not, the application is rebuilt rather than restyled, and section 4.1 becomes the smaller of the two problems.

Two points keep the rest in proportion. Several of the fourteen discussion items are requests for information not yet provided rather than objections to the design, and they close with an answer rather than with work. All five delivery and automation items share a single cause, the use of an external code repository, which SITE taking over the pipeline settles as one decision rather than five.

The four outright rejections were the Google artificial intelligence service, the WhatsApp messaging channel, a thirty-minute access token and a thirty-day session. The last two are already corrected in the design and the first is already replaced by the on-site model, but SITE has not been told: the checklist it returned still records all three as rejected. They must be re-presented in writing. Only the WhatsApp channel remains genuinely to be withdrawn.

4. What moving would cost

4.1 The design rebuild, which is what moves the date

SITE requires the platform to follow the national design system for Saudi government platforms, published by the Digital Government Authority. It is the standard reference for the interfaces of government platforms, and the current design was rejected against it. Its exact edition and the route to certifying compliance are stated here as reported and must be confirmed with the Authority or with SITE.

The standard is supplied as a component library, design tokens and design kits, and appears to be published for the web technologies most government platforms use. No distribution covering the two technologies this platform is built on has been found.

What that means, and what is still assumption. The website and the Control Panel are built in Blazor, which renders ordinary web pages, so the standard's tokens and stylesheets are likely to be adoptable largely as published. The mobile application is built in Flutter, which draws its own interface and can consume none of it, so for the application the design system has to be rebuilt from the standard's tokens and design kits, along with the shared component library used across the three clients. This is the work that moves the launch date, and it rests on an assumption about what the official distribution contains. Confirming it is the first thing to do, not the last.

4.2 The handover of operations

SITE would publish, deploy, run, test and monitor the platform, and would submit the mobile applications to the stores. Three parties then hold clear and separate responsibilities: the development company builds the software and hands it over, SITE runs it, and the events company runs the forum itself.

One practical point in the platform's favour. Both mobile applications are already built under the customer's own identity rather than the development company's. A change of publisher therefore does not force a new application identity and does not break the upgrade path for anyone who has already installed the application. What transfers is the store account and the signing keys, which is an account transfer rather than a fresh publication.

4.3 Control during the forum

With publishing, operation, testing and monitoring at SITE, the team cannot release a correction or inspect the production system during the event without SITE performing the action. The forum runs on fixed dates and an outage inside it cannot be rescheduled. If the platform moves to SITE, a support arrangement covering the three forum days has to be agreed with them in writing, naming who is available, how quickly, and with what authority to act.

5. Recommendation

Move to SITE, in two steps rather than as a single event. Step one is to obtain the design standard and estimate the rebuild, and to settle whether SITE accepts the mobile technology at all. Step two is to take the rebuild and the migration together as one funded piece of work, with the forum date set against the estimate rather than ahead of it.

The reasoning is that SITE is not truly optional. Approval depends on it, the Ministry's systems are hosted there, and the High Level Design already delivered to the Ministry states that the platform is hosted on SITE. Staying on STC does not remove that requirement; it defers it to a point where the move is more expensive and riskier, because the platform will by then be carrying live data, real users, published addresses and issued certificates.

If the forum date cannot absorb the design rebuild, then the position to record is to launch the 2026 forum on the current host and move to SITE immediately afterwards, with the rebuild scheduled and funded as its own piece of work. That is a legitimate choice, but it must be taken deliberately and written down, and the High Level Design must then be corrected to describe the host actually in use. Leaving the decision open reaches the same outcome without recording it.

6. Decisions required

#	Decision	Owner	What it blocks
1	Move to SITE, or launch the 2026 forum on the current host and move afterwards.	Project owner	Everything below. Until it is taken, the delivered design and the running system continue to disagree.
2	Obtain the national design standard, its official distribution, its licence and the route to certifying compliance.	Development company, with the Digital Government Authority or SITE	The rebuild cannot be estimated, so the effect on the launch date cannot be stated. This is the one number the owner is missing.
3	Settle whether SITE accepts the technology the mobile application is built in.	Project owner with SITE	Whether the application is restyled or rebuilt. Potentially larger than decision 2.
4	Agree who pays for the design rebuild and the migration.	Project owner and the Ministry	The rebuild cannot start.
5	Re-present to SITE the three items	Development	Three items that remain recorded as rejected on

#	Decision	Owner	What it blocks
	already corrected: the access token, the session lifetime and the replacement of the Google service.	company	SITE's own checklist despite being fixed.
6	Agree the support arrangement covering the three forum days once operations sit with SITE.	Project owner with SITE	Nothing can be corrected during the forum without it. Agree it before the platform moves, not before the event.
7	Agree the transfer of the mobile store accounts and signing keys.	Development company with SITE	Any application release made after the transfer.
8	Answer the checklist items that ask a question rather than for change: the request rate limits and the purpose of the application key.	Development company	Two of the fourteen open items directly. Two more, the administrator second factor and the email activation, await a cyber review SITE performs, for which the development company can only supply the detail. Five more close with the pipeline handover under decision 1.
9	Withdraw the WhatsApp channel formally from the documented scope.	Development company	A rejected item remaining in the delivered documents.

7. What this brief does not cover

It does not state what is or is not built today, feature by feature, beyond the three cases in section 3.1 where the design and the deployment differ. It does not reissue the High Level Design, the Solution Design Document or the Business Requirements Document, all three of which need correcting once this decision is taken. Two corrections are already known and are recorded here so they are not lost: the High Level Design names SITE as the host while the platform runs elsewhere, and the Business Requirements Document states that the development company publishes the mobile applications, which stops being true if SITE takes publishing.